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TEACHER LESSON PLAN

Created in God's Image

Grades 5–8 · Religion

THE 45 MINUTES

5 min	12 min	22 min	6 min
HOOK	TEACH	ACTIVITY	PRAYER

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

What students will understand

Students will explore how the Harlem Renaissance was a profound affirmation of human dignity rooted in the theological conviction that every person is made *imago Dei* — in the image and likeness of God. They will connect Catholic Social Teaching Principle 1 (Life and Dignity of the Human Person) to the cultural and artistic work of the Renaissance, and reflect on their own responsibility to affirm the dignity of others.

STANDARDS AND THEMES

- **CST Principle 1** — Life and Dignity of the Human Person: every human being is created in God's image and deserves respect regardless of race, status, or achievement
- **CST Principle 7** — Solidarity: we are one human family; our responsibilities to one another cross racial, cultural, and national boundaries
- **Genesis 1:26–27** — "Let us make humankind in our image, according to our likeness": the theological foundation of human dignity
- **Matthew 25:40** — "Whatever you did for one of the least of these brothers and sisters of mine, you did for me"

MATERIALS NEEDED

- Bible (classroom set or projected)
- Projected or printed Aaron Douglas image — *Song of the Towers* or *Aspects of Negro Life*
- Differentiated handouts — one per student

HOOK · 5 MINUTES

Two questions

"I'm going to ask you two questions. First: what does it mean to be made in God's image? Take 30 seconds and write one sentence. Second: if every person is made in God's image — equally — what does it mean when a society treats some people as less than others?"

Take 4–5 responses to each. Hold the tension between the theological claim and the historical reality. Don't resolve it yet.

DIRECT INSTRUCTION · 12 MINUTES

Imago Dei and the Harlem Renaissance

Establish the theological foundation: *imago Dei* (Genesis 1:26–27) means every human person possesses inherent, irreducible dignity — not earned by achievement, status, race, or talent. This is not a social convention; it is a theological claim about the nature of reality.

"The artists, writers, and musicians of the Harlem Renaissance were making exactly this claim — but in paint and poetry and jazz. Langston Hughes was saying: 'I, too, am America.' Aaron Douglas was painting figures without individual faces because the point was not one person's dignity — it was every Black person's dignity. That is a theological argument expressed in art."

Introduce the historical context briefly: Jim Crow laws, segregation, and the cultural response of the Harlem Renaissance as an assertion that Black life, art, and culture were not only equal but magnificent. Connect to CST Principle 7 — Solidarity: what happens

to one member of the human family affects all of us.

ACTIVITY · 22 MINUTES

GREEN LEVEL
MORE SUPPORT

Read Genesis 1:26–27 and a short summary of CST Principle 1. Answer four guided questions connecting the theological text to the Harlem Renaissance. Draw or describe one moment from the Renaissance that expressed human dignity.

YELLOW LEVEL
GRADE LEVEL

Read two scripture passages and apply CST Principle 1 to two specific examples from the Harlem Renaissance. Write a reflective paragraph on what it means to affirm someone's *imago Dei* through creative work — and what students' responsibility is today.

RED LEVEL
GO DEEPER

Theological analysis: how does the Harlem Renaissance represent a response to the systematic violation of *imago Dei*? Write a structured theological reflection using scripture, CST, and specific Renaissance examples. Respond to: can art be a form of prayer or prophetic witness?

CLOSING PRAYER · 6 MINUTES

Invite a student to lead a brief prayer of gratitude for the artists, writers, and musicians who insisted on the dignity of every person — and a prayer for the courage to do the same in their own lives.

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

Option 1 — Visit the exhibition: Bring your class to experience the phonograph, the Great Migration Map, the Jazz Lab, and more. Ask your librarian to arrange a visit. **Option 2 — Virtual visit:**

minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance

THEOLOGICAL FRAMEWORK

Imago Dei (Genesis 1:26–27): The conviction that every human person is created in the image and likeness of God is the foundation of the Catholic understanding of human dignity. This dignity is not earned; it is given. It cannot be taken away by law, custom, poverty, or prejudice. It applies equally to every human person regardless of race, gender, age, ability, or status.

CST Principle 1 — Life and Dignity of the Human Person: Catholic Social Teaching begins with the affirmation that human life is sacred. Society must be organized to protect and affirm this dignity — not undermine it. When laws, social structures, or cultural attitudes deny the dignity of any group of people, they are in direct contradiction to this foundational principle.

Prophetic witness: The biblical prophets spoke out when society violated the dignity of the poor and marginalized. The Harlem Renaissance artists were engaging in a similar prophetic witness — insisting that the world see what it was refusing to acknowledge.

SCRIPTURE CONNECTIONS

Genesis 1:26–27	*Imago Dei* — foundational text on human dignity
Psalm 139:13–14	"You knit me together in my mother's womb... I am fearfully and wonderfully made" — personal affirmation of each person's sacred worth
Matthew 25:31–46	"Whatever you did for one of the least of these" — the practical expression of human dignity in action
Galatians 3:28	"There is neither Jew nor Greek, slave nor free, male nor female, for you are all one in Christ Jesus" — Paul's radical statement of human equality
Amos 5:24	"Let justice roll down like waters, and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream" — prophetic demand for social justice

CROSS-CURRICULAR AND ASSESSMENT NOTES

- **ELA:** Langston Hughes's "I, Too" is a direct assertion of *imago Dei* in poetic form — "I, too, am America" is a theological claim as well as a political one
- **Art:** Aaron Douglas's featureless silhouettes say: the individual face doesn't matter — what matters is the shared dignity of every figure. This is a visual argument for *imago Dei*.
- **Social Studies:** The contrast between CST's affirmation of human dignity and the legal reality of Jim Crow is a powerful case study in structural sin
- **Assessment:** Reflective journal entry; prayer or psalm written in the style of the biblical texts; presentation connecting one artist or writer to a specific CST principle